

bore into my soul; it was a motherly decree that put the trial to an end with the jury's unanimous verdict: "Failure, with a vote of no confidence."

Mom suggested, "The grocery store is hiring a deli manager, why don't you go down there and check it out?" As if my college education and struggles for the last five years were to eclipse at the deli counter, cutting blocks of bologna and ladling potato salad to the neighborhood soccer moms. Thanks for the job tip, but I'll pass.

MY BLIZZARD OF AWAKENING

It took the pain of a cold Chicago blizzard to throw me into the crossroads of life. It was a dark, frigid night, and I was dead tired working as a limo driver. My shoes were drenched from wet snow while I fought a migraine headache. The four aspirins I chased two hours earlier had no effect. I wanted to get home but couldn't. I was stuck in a blizzard and my usual routes were snowed in. I pulled to the shoulder of a faintly lit road and felt the cold chill of melted snow crawl up my legs from my toes. I put the limo in park and faced myself in dead silence with nothing but the fall of snowflakes to remind me how much I hated winter. I dazed at the cigarette-burned ceiling of the limousine and thought, "What the hell am I doing? Is this what my life has become?"

Sitting on an empty road in a blizzard in the dark of the night out in the middle of nowhere, I'd had it. Sometimes clarity washes over you like a peaceful breeze and other times it hits you over the head like a falling Steinway piano. For me, it was the latter. A sharp declaration overpowered my brain: "You cannot live another day like this!" If I was going to survive, I needed to change.

THE DECISION TO CHANGE

The harsh winter shot me into swift action. I decided to change. I decided to take control over something I thought was uncontrollable: my environment. I decided to relocate—to where, I didn't know, and at that moment, I didn't care.

In an instant, I felt powerful. The velocity of that choice infused my miserable existence with hope and a small drip of happiness. My failures evaporated and I felt reborn. *Suddenly a dead-end road converged with a dream.* It just wasn't about the decision to move; it was about taking control and knowing that I had a choice.

With this new power, I considered options that never had dawned on me. I asked a simple question: "If I could live anywhere in the country without restraint, where would I live?" I thought about the things important to me, and circled five cities on a map. The next month I moved, or I should say, escaped.

THE MERGE FROM SLOWLANE TO FASTLANE

I arrived in Phoenix with 900 bucks, no job, no friends, and no family—just 330 days of sun and a burning desire to hit the Fastlane. My possessions included